Make Sure the Next Person Caring for Your Wife Knows What Changed

Take apart one lost message, list the updates that keep recurring, write a handoff that names an owner, and track what hasn't been confirmed.

Where you are

Your wife's care now passes between you, your daughter, a home aide, and the clinic. Last week you told someone about a change and found out later it never reached the person who needed it. Everyone is sending messages; nobody is sure who is holding the ball.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can explain what went wrong with a recent handoff, describe the updates that happen every week, and send one message that says what changed, what's needed, and who owns it.

A one-page handoff sheet: Updates That Recur, Our Handoff Message Format, Sent and Waiting for Acknowledgment, and Unanswered Items.

Before you start

- A recent example of something that didn't get through, as you remember it.
- The texts, emails, or notes from the last week or two.
- A sense of who is usually on which day or shift. Rough is fine; one good example is enough to start.

PROMPT 1

Take apart one message that didn't land

WHY THIS MATTERS

The fastest way to fix handoffs is to look closely at one that failed. Not to blame anyone. To see where the information stopped.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The story of one recent breakdown: what you knew, who you told, how, and who found out late.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Something about my wife's care didn't get through to the right person recently. Here is what happened, as best I can tell:

> [DESCRIBE THE BREAKDOWN: WHAT CHANGED, WHO YOU TOLD, HOW, AND WHO FOUND OUT LATE]
>
> Lay it out as a timeline with these columns: WHAT WAS KNOWN, WHO KNEW IT, HOW IT WAS SENT, WHO IT WAS MEANT FOR, and WHETHER THEY CONFIRMED THEY GOT IT. Then point to the exact step where the chain broke. Describe it as a gap in the process, not as a mistake by a person. Finish with two or three questions I could ask the people involved to understand what they expected to happen.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The step where the message was sent but never confirmed. That is almost always where it broke.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask the person who was supposed to receive it how they prefer to get that kind of update.

PROMPT 2

List the updates that happen every week

WHY THIS MATTERS

Some handoffs are one-offs. Most repeat: the aide tells you how the morning went, you tell your daughter before her turn, someone calls the clinic back. Those are the ones worth building a habit around.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your messages and notes from the last week or two.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the messages, texts, and notes about my wife's care from the last couple of weeks:
>
> [PASTE OR SUMMARIZE THEM, WITH NAMES REMOVED]
>
> Find the handoffs that recur. A handoff is any time one person passes information or a task to another. Give me a table: TYPE OF UPDATE, WHO USUALLY SENDS IT, WHO NEEDS TO GET IT, HOW IT TRAVELS NOW, and HOW OFTEN. Include family-to-family handoffs, like me updating my daughter before she takes over, and family-to-provider handoffs. Then list any update where the receiver is unclear, or where I seem to be telling several people and hoping one of them acts.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Updates with a vague receiver, and updates where you're broadcasting rather than handing off.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

For the provider handoffs, ask the provider which channel and which person they want the family to use.

PROMPT 3

Write one handoff that names an owner

WHY THIS MATTERS

'FYI, she didn't eat much today' is information. 'She didn't eat much today, can you watch dinner and let me know' is a handoff. The difference is a receiver and an owner.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

One real update you need to send soon.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I need to send an update about my wife's care. Here is what I'd normally write:
>
> [PASTE YOUR DRAFT OR NOTES]
>
> Rewrite it as a short handoff message with five labeled lines: TO (one named person), WHAT CHANGED, WHAT NEEDS TO HAPPEN NEXT, WHO OWNS THAT, and PLEASE CONFIRM (a one-line request to reply when they've seen it). Keep it under 120 words and in my plain voice. If my notes mention a medication or a symptom, report exactly what I observed and do not add any interpretation or suggest any change. If I haven't said who owns the next action, leave that line blank and tell me so rather than guessing.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A message one person could read in thirty seconds and know what's theirs.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Send it to that one person, and note the time you sent it.

PROMPT 4

Build your one-page handoff sheet

WHY THIS MATTERS

Once you can see the recurring updates and have a format that works, you need somewhere to track what's been sent and what's still hanging. That is what keeps responsibility from disappearing.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've worked out about how care information moves between the people helping my wife:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Make me a one-page handoff sheet with four headings: UPDATES THAT RECUR (from the table, with sender and receiver), OUR HANDOFF MESSAGE FORMAT (the five-line format, blank and ready to copy), SENT AND WAITING FOR ACKNOWLEDGMENT (a short table with columns for date, to whom, what, and confirmed yes or no), and UNANSWERED ITEMS (anything from the breakdown or the messages where ownership is still unclear). Leave the provider channel rows marked 'confirm with provider' rather than filling them in. Don't add advice about what the care team should do with the information.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A sheet where every open item has a name next to it or is clearly marked as not yet owned.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Update the sheet after each handoff this week, then carry on to the step below.

Give every handoff the same starting point

Handoffs fail when people are working from different pictures of your wife's situation. The care interview puts that picture into one Family Care Profile, so the next person starts from the same place you do.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›